Legislator introduces bill to ban sale of candies containing harmful chemicals

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A local California legislator presented an initiative that would prohibit in the state the sale and manufacture of foods containing dangerous chemicals for health, especially candies and soft drinks, seeking to homologate a similar measure approved in the European Union.

The bill by Democratic legislator Jesse Gabriel would make California the first state to ban Skittles or Hostess Ding Dongs, among other candies, unless they change their formulas to be less harmful to health, since their chemicals may pose risks such as decreased immune response, hyperactivity in children and increased risk of cancer.

"I love Skittles. I love Wild Berry Skittles. I eat them all the time," the Gabriel lawmaker told the Los Angeles Times. "I would vote against a bill to ban Skittles. What we're really trying to get them to do is change their recipes. These are all non-essential ingredients," he explained.

California lawmakers backing the bill pointed to a series of scientific studies that showed links between the chemicals, which include red dye, titanium dioxide, potassium bromate, brominated vegetable oil and propylparaben, and health problems.

In a study cited by Gabriel's office, titanium dioxide, used in Skittles as a dye, was found to be associated with decreased immune responses in rats.

A lawsuit filed last year in California against Mars, which makes Skittles and M&M's and Milky Way chocolates, claimed the colorful candies were "unfit for human consumption" because of titanium dioxide.

The substance is approved by the Food and Drug Administration (FDA), but it states that it cannot represent more than 1% of the weight of the food.

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